

# Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 42

**Time allowed:** 1 hour 50 minutes

**Total marks for Sections B and C:** 45

## Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [ ] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

## Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

**Text 3:** A teenage girl is sent to clear her late aunt's attic and discovers a leather-bound diary that holds an unexpected reference to her own mother.

**1**

The attic smelled of warm dust and old paper, as if the room itself had been holding its breath since Aunt Vivienne's funeral the month before. My mother had been the one to volunteer me — "Mira is patient with old things," she had said, with the brisk cheerfulness she used whenever she did not want a discussion — and so I had climbed the ladder alone, with a stack of empty boxes under one arm and a roll of brown tape under the other. I told myself it would take an afternoon. It did not.

**2**

For the first hour I worked quickly, sorting hatboxes and cracked picture frames into neat piles by the small round window. Aunt Vivienne had been the family's quietest aunt, the one who sent careful birthday cards and never overstayed at Christmas, and her belongings had the same restrained dignity. There were no embarrassing souvenirs, no half-finished knitting; only books, letters tied with ribbon, and a single shoebox of photographs in which everyone, including my grandmother, looked unexpectedly young.

**3**

The diary was at the bottom of a trunk I had nearly missed. It was bound in oxblood leather, soft with handling, and the brass clasp opened at a touch. Inside, the handwriting was small and very neat — the handwriting of a woman who had been taught, once, that script was a kind of manners. The first entry was dated the summer Aunt Vivienne had been nineteen. I had not known she kept a diary. I am not sure anyone had.

**4**

I should have closed it then. I knew, even as my thumb moved across the first page, that this was a private thing, written by a young woman who could not have imagined her teenage niece sitting cross-legged on the attic floor forty years later. But the page was already turning, and the room was very quiet, and the dust hung in the slanting light like something patient. I read.

5

Between two of the middle pages, an envelope had been tucked. It was small, cream-coloured, sealed once and never opened again — the wax along the flap had gone slightly grey with age but was still firmly shut. There was no name on the front, only a date in the same careful hand. I held it for a long time before I worked the flap loose with my fingernail, more slowly than I needed to, as though slow unsealing were a kind of permission. Inside was a single folded sheet, and at the top of it, in the centre, was my mother's name.

6

I do not need to repeat what the letter said. It is enough to say that Aunt Vivienne, at nineteen, had known something about my mother — something old, something gentle, something my mother had never spoken of — and had chosen to write it down once and then put it away. The letter was not unkind. It was, if anything, protective: an older sister's quiet record of a younger sister's secret, kept for safety and never used. I read it twice. Then I sat for a long while with the page open in my lap and the diary closed beside me, and I listened to the house breathing through its old timbers.

7

There were, I knew, two honest choices. I could hand the letter to my mother — and let her decide whether the past, having been written down once, deserved to be read again. Or I could fold it back into the diary, retie the ribbon, and place the trunk among the boxes for the attic clearance, where in time it would become someone else's puzzle, or no one's at all. I sat with both choices for what must have been an hour. The dust shifted in the light. Downstairs, my mother called up to ask whether I wanted tea.

8

In the end I refolded the letter along its old creases and slid it back into the envelope, and the envelope back into the diary, and I carried the diary down the ladder with both hands. I did not give it to my mother that evening. I have not, yet, decided when I will. But I know now what I did not know that morning — that the dead leave words behind them, and that the living must choose, very carefully, what to do with the silence those words break.

### From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says the attic “had been holding its breath since Aunt Vivienne's funeral the month before.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about the atmosphere of the attic. [2]

2. The narrator's mother spoke “with the brisk cheerfulness she used whenever she did not want a discussion.” What does this tell us about the mother? [2]

### From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator describes Aunt Vivienne's belongings as having a “restrained dignity.” Give **two** details from Paragraph 2 that support this description. [2]

### From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator says Aunt Vivienne's handwriting was that “of a woman who had been taught, once, that script was a kind of manners.” What does this suggest about Aunt Vivienne's upbringing? [2]

### From Paragraph 4

5. The narrator writes, “I should have closed it then.”

- (a) What does this short sentence suggest about the narrator's feelings as she opened the diary? [1]  
(b) Give **one** detail from Paragraph 4 that shows the narrator continued reading despite these feelings. [1]

**From Paragraph 5**

6. The narrator says she worked the envelope’s flap loose “more slowly than I needed to, as though slow unsealing were a kind of permission.” Explain how the language used here makes the moment feel significant. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

**From Paragraph 6**

7. The narrator describes the letter as “not unkind” and “if anything, protective.” What does this suggest about Aunt Vivienne’s reasons for writing the letter? [2]

8. The narrator listens to “the house breathing through its old timbers.” What does the word **breathing** suggest about the narrator’s state of mind at this moment? [1]

**From Paragraph 7**

9. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 7 that shows how difficult the narrator finds the decision. [1]

**From Paragraph 8**

10. The narrator says, “I have not, yet, decided when I will.” What does the word **yet** suggest about her thinking? [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

**Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]**

**Text 4: A feature article on the cultural and economic weight of K-pop, and the limits of “manufactured” success.**

**1**

A little over a decade ago, the idea that a South Korean boy band might headline Wembley Stadium, address the United Nations, or move the share price of a publicly listed company would have struck most observers as fanciful. Today, none of these things is remarkable. K-pop — a label that began as shorthand for a domestic genre but now covers an entire export industry — has become one of the most studied cultural exports of the twenty-first century. In 2022, South Korea’s music exports were valued at more than 1.1 billion United States dollars, a figure that has roughly tripled since 2017, and the seven members of BTS alone have been estimated to contribute several billion dollars annually to the South Korean economy through tourism, merchandise, and album sales.

**2**

The scale is striking, but the machinery behind it is more striking still. The K-pop “idol” is not, in the ordinary sense, discovered. He or she is selected — often at thirteen or fourteen — through global auditions and then placed inside a training system that can last anywhere from three to seven years. Trainees live in shared dormitories, attend daily lessons in vocal performance, dance, foreign languages, and media presentation, and are evaluated, ranked and occasionally released at quarterly assessments. The cost of training a single debut-ready idol has been estimated at over 100,000 United States dollars; the cost of training the many who never debut is absorbed, quietly, by the agencies that run them.

**3**

Once an act has launched, its success depends less on radio play — long a declining force in any case — than on the choreography of fan attention online. K-pop fandoms are organised with a discipline that startles even seasoned music marketers: they coordinate streaming campaigns to push a song up algorithmic charts, mobilise donations in their idols’ names, and police one another’s behaviour in the comments under official posts. The relationship is unusually two-way. Idols livestream to their fans almost daily, learn the languages of their largest overseas markets, and refer to fans by affectionate group names. Few other genres have built so direct a circuit between performer and audience.

**4**

This intimacy comes at a cost the industry has, until recently, been reluctant to discuss. The Korean Press Foundation has reported that depression and anxiety among active idols are significantly above the population average for adults in their twenties, and several high-profile deaths in the past decade have forced agencies to acknowledge what their own contracts had long discouraged: that a performer who is on call to an international fandom twenty-four hours a day, whose appearance is monitored gram by gram, and whose every public utterance can be turned into a headline within minutes, is a performer under conditions that no ordinary workplace would permit.

**5**

The South Korean government, for its part, has read the export figures with interest. Since the late 1990s, Seoul has explicitly cultivated what it calls the “Hallyu” or Korean Wave — the bundle of dramas, films, food, cosmetics and music that travels under the broader banner of Korean culture — as an instrument of soft power. State agencies subsidise overseas concerts, fund language-learning programmes that ride on the popularity of K-pop, and lean on the genre to soften the country’s image in regions where its diplomatic footprint is small. A 2021 government white paper described culture, frankly, as the country’s “third pillar” of foreign influence, after trade and defence.

**6**

There are limits, however, to what manufactured success can accomplish. Critics argue that the very

perfection of K-pop — its synchronised choreography, its glossy production, its tightly managed scandals — leaves little room for the awkwardness from which durable art often grows. A song produced by committee, lip-synced over a dance routine rehearsed for eleven hours a day, may travel further than a scrappier rival, but it is harder to remember in twenty years. The genre’s defenders reply that this misreads the form: K-pop, like opera or musical theatre, is a **spectacle**, and to judge it by the standards of a singer-songwriter is to mistake its purpose.

**7**

Where the argument lands depends, in the end, on what one believes culture is for. If it exists to express a single artist’s private vision, K-pop will always look engineered. If it exists, instead, to gather millions of people across borders into a shared and slightly improbable feeling — a stadium of strangers singing a chorus in a language most of them do not speak — then the genre has, by any honest measure, succeeded. What seems certain is that the K-pop model is no longer a Korean curiosity: agencies in Tokyo, Los Angeles and London are now copying it, line by line, in the hope of producing the next global act. The question is no longer whether the formula works. It is whether the people inside it can be cared for as carefully as the brand they are asked to sustain.

**From Paragraph 1**

**12.** The writer says the idea that a South Korean boy band might address the United Nations “would have struck most observers as fanciful.” Explain, in your own words, what this tells us about how attitudes towards K-pop have changed. [2]

**From Paragraph 2**

**13.** According to Paragraph 2, give **two** features of the K-pop training system that show how controlled it is. [2]

**14.** The writer says the cost of training those “who never debut is absorbed, quietly, by the agencies that run them.” What does the word **quietly** suggest about the industry? [2]

**From Paragraph 3**

**15.** The writer says K-pop’s success depends on “the choreography of fan attention online.” Explain what the word **choreography** suggests about how fandoms operate. [2]

**16.** Give **two** details from Paragraph 3 that show the relationship between idols and fans is “unusually two-way.” [2]

**From Paragraph 4**

**17.** The writer says the working conditions of idols are ones “that no ordinary workplace would permit.” Why does the writer make this comparison? [2]

**From Paragraph 5**

**18.** Explain, in your own words, what is meant by **soft power** in the context of Paragraph 5. [2]

**19.** The 2021 white paper describes culture as the country’s “third pillar” of foreign influence. What does the word **pillar** suggest about the role of culture in South Korean foreign policy? [2]

**From Paragraph 6**

**20.** The writer says K-pop’s “tightly managed scandals” leave “little room for the awkwardness from which durable art often grows.” What is the writer’s **tone** in this sentence? **[1]**

**From Paragraph 7**

**21.** The writer ends the article with the question of whether the people inside K-pop “can be cared for as carefully as the brand they are asked to sustain.” Explain what is **effective** about ending the article in this way. **[2]**

**22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]**

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **how K-pop achieves its global commercial success**, and **what costs and limits accompany that success**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

**K-pop achieves its global success by ...**

— END OF PAPER —